



Photographs by CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

THERESA McNABB, left, was the final patient at Glenn Medical Center in Willows, Calif., when it closed.

Alter Cal Fire program, court says

The initiative risks worsening blazes by removing native plants, ruling states.

By NOAH HAGGERTY

In a case that calls into question plant clearing techniques that have become fundamental to the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection, or Cal Fire, the San Diego County Superior Court has ordered the agency to amend a pro-

gram to reduce wildfire risk across the state because it could make things worse.

The years-long legal action, filed by the California Chaparral Institute and Endangered Habitats League against the Board of Forestry and Fire Protection within Cal Fire, highlights deep rifts between ecologists' and firefighters' approaches to solving California's wildfire crisis.

Richard Halsey, director of the California Chaparral Institute, was elated. "Chaparral and sage scrub is more than 10% of the state," he

said.

"Despite all the rhetoric about how we love biodiversity, you're going to wipe out where most of the biodiversity is in the state," and in the process make the landscape more flammable, Halsey said of the Cal Fire plan.

Cal Fire's Vegetation Treatment Program aims to use prescribed fire plus tree and brush cutting to reduce the risk of a wildfire igniting, exploding out of control and jeopardizing lives and property. In doing so, the agency also tries to nurture the biodiversity of native species

and protect clean water and soil health.

"The California Vegetation Treatment Program is one critical tool of many to address the state's catastrophic wildfire crisis," Tony Andersen, executive officer of the Board of Forestry and Fire Protection, said in a statement. "We appreciate the months of collaborative work spent with the Chaparral Institute, Endangered Habitats League, and others to find interim solutions that address their feedback."

[See Cal Fire, A6]

Keeping ICE actions in the public eye

The Save America Movement records raids, helps migrants.

By MELISSA GOMEZ AND KAREN GARCIA

As the Liberty Van rolled into the Home Depot, its driver slowed, lowered the window and waved at day laborers standing around the

parking lot.

It had rained all morning and the overcast clouds trapped a chill in the air. Still, on a recent Friday, day laborers milled around even as it began to drizzle again. A pastor, a Navy veteran, an immigration lawyer and cameraman got out of the Liberty Van — *camioneta de la libertad* in Spanish — and greeted the day laborers while offering them water and snacks.

Since June in Los Angeles, federal immigration agents have destabilized daily life by raiding neighborhoods, worksites and Home Depots — popular gathering spots for day laborers, many of whom lack U.S. citizenship. In turn, several "rapid-response" groups have surged into action to aid those targeted in the raids and to document their treatment.

One of these organiza-

tions is the Save America Movement, which runs the Liberty Vans and includes a bipartisan leadership that is far more politically connected than that of many grassroots organizations. The group was founded by Steve Schmidt, a former top aide to Republican Sen. John McCain of Arizona, and Mary Corcoran, a longtime public relations specialist, with a steering

[See Watchdog, A6]

Rural hospital's closure may be first of many

A medical center in Willows lost 'critical access' status, and crucial funds, leaving a town without care

By JESSICA GARRISON

WILLOWS, Calif. — As hospital staff carted away medical equipment from abandoned patient rooms, Theresa McNabb, 74, roused herself and painstakingly applied makeup for the first time in weeks, finishing with a mauve lipstick that made her eyes pop.

"I feel a little anxiety," McNabb said. She was still taking multiple intravenous antibiotics for the massive infection that had almost killed her, was unsteady on her feet and was unsure how she was going to manage shopping and cooking food for herself once she returned to her apartment after six weeks in the hospital.

But she couldn't stay at Glenn Medical Center. It was closing.

The hospital — which for more than seven decades has treated residents of its small farm town about 75 miles north of Sacramento, along with countless victims of car crashes on nearby Interstate 5 and a surprising number of crop-duster pilots wounded in accidents — shut its doors on Oct. 21.

McNabb was the last patient.

Nurses and other hospital workers gathered at her room to ceremonially push her wheelchair outside and into the doors of a medical transport van. Then they stood on the lawn, looking bereft.

They had all just lost their jobs. Their town had just lost one of its largest employers. And the residents — many of whom are poor — had lost their access to emergency medical care. What would happen to all of them now? Would local residents' health grow worse? Would some of them die preventable deaths?

These are questions that elected officials and policymakers may soon be confronting in rural communities across California and the nation. Cuts to Medicaid funding and the Affordable Care Act are likely to roll down from Washington and hit small hospitals already teetering on the brink of financial collapse. Even before these cuts hit, a 2022 study found that half of the hospitals in California were operating in the red. Already

[See Hospitals, A8]



KELLIE AMARU, a licensed vocational nurse, reacts after a co-worker leaves after their last shift.

In this bar scene, it's all about finding a roommate

By KAILYN BROWN

Inside a dim New Orleans-style bar in Hollywood, dozens of strangers mingle under the thump of pop music while nursing complimentary cocktails. Each person is sporting a name tag along with a personality sticker, or a few, that best captures their vibe. Neat freak. Plant parent. Night owl. Craft beer aficionado.

The scene reads like a friendly singles mixer, but listen to their conversations and it's clear the chemistry they are hoping for isn't romantic. They are here to find the perfect roommate.

Hosted by rental platform SpareRoom, the monthly "speed roommating" event connects people who are renting rooms with those who are looking for one in a low-key, in-person setting — no endless online profiles to fill out, no awkward interviews. Loosely based on speed dating, sans the timed interactions, attendees put on name tags indicating either "I need a room" or "I need a roommate" along with their ideal budget and neighborhoods. Then they wander freely. One woman passed out fliers for a furnished studio in downtown L.A. with air conditioning, a Murphy

[See Roommate, A6]

China's humanoid robots are steps ahead of Musk's

By Stephanie Yang

As Elon Musk touted plans to eventually manufacture an army of Tesla bots in Silicon Valley this month, humanoid robots were already being produced and sold to consumers in China.

Chinese and U.S. companies have begun a battle to build the world's best bots. Although it's early days, experts say China is leading in the quantity of robots delivered to consumers, while America is ahead in the quality of robots demonstrated.

Musk danced with Tesla's Optimus bots at his company's shareholder meeting and outlined plans for a factory in Fremont that he said will someday have the capacity to build a million bots a year,

which would sell for around \$20,000 in today's dollars. One of China's leading robotics companies, Unitree Robotics, already has a humanoid robot on the market that can walk, dance and perform basic tasks. Its least expensive version costs around \$6,000.

Although the inexpensive Unitree bot is far less sophisticated than Optimus, its early entrance into the real-world market at an affordable price demonstrates China's edge. The country has the parts, the production facilities and the pool of labor required to bring the rapidly evolving robots to market quickly and cheaply, said

[See Robots, A11]



HAN SUYUAN China News Service

STUDENTS in China last month interact with a teacher's assistant robot.

A young artist worthy of a priceless violin

Ray Ushikubo, 24, will be performing in L.A. on the Playfair, made by Guarneri 'del Gesù.'

By EMMA MADDEN

For years, Colin Maki and his associates — purveyors of some of the finest and rarest violins ever made — had been circling the Playfair, an ultrarare model crafted by the famed luthier Guarneri "del Gesù" in 1741. Little is known about the Playfair's passage through the centuries, but its profile suggests a life spent moving between gifted hands. It was last sold by W.E. Hill & Sons, a storied London shop. From there, Maki says, it passed to "a noteworthy collector, then another one, and then a very prominent musician," who eventually chose to part with it, relinquishing the instrument to Maki and entrusting him to find a player worthy of continuing its legacy.

"An opportunity arose," Maki says, "to play matchmaker." The artist they landed on was a 24-year-old



ROBERT GAUTHIER L.A. Times

RAY USHIKUBO has the Playfair, one of the finest, rarest violins ever made, on indefinite loan.

from San Gabriel, who plays both violin and piano: Ray Ushikubo.

Ushikubo has performed at Carnegie Hall and Walt Disney Concert Hall, appeared on NBC's "Tonight Show With Jay Leno" and won numerous awards including the Davidson Fellow Laureate Award and the Hilton Head International Piano Competition. Now comes one of his greatest feats: his debut on the Playfair, one of the most exceptional

[See Violin, A12]

Keeping up with this holiday run

Community comes back together for the Pacific Palisides Turkey Trot. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

A brotherhood forged by tragedy

Angels manager and survivor in deadly crash share lasting bond, says Bill Shaikin. **SPORTS, B10**

Before it was the Magic Kingdom

A San Francisco museum exhibit traces Disneyland's beginning. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Not as warm.
L.A. Basin: 72/51. **B6**

Climate **A7**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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